

CITA01 – Foundations of City Studies Summer 2026

July 27, 2026

Course Instructor: Olivia Bernard

AI and
Inequality

Objectives

Discussion

AI and Urban
Change

Course
Evaluation

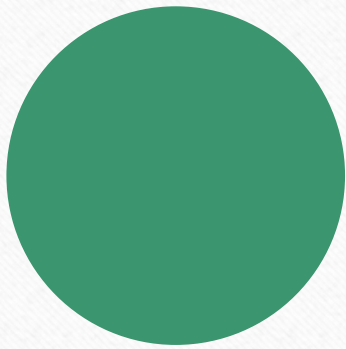
The City is Not
A Computer

COURSE EVALUATION

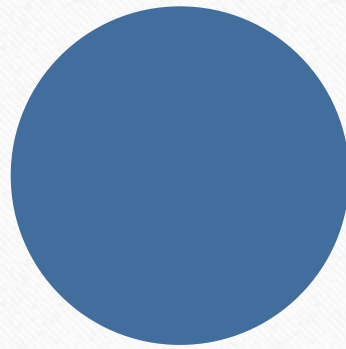
Please remember to
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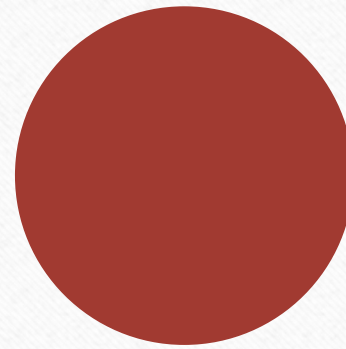
Tutorial Schedule



~~JULY 6~~



~~JULY 20~~



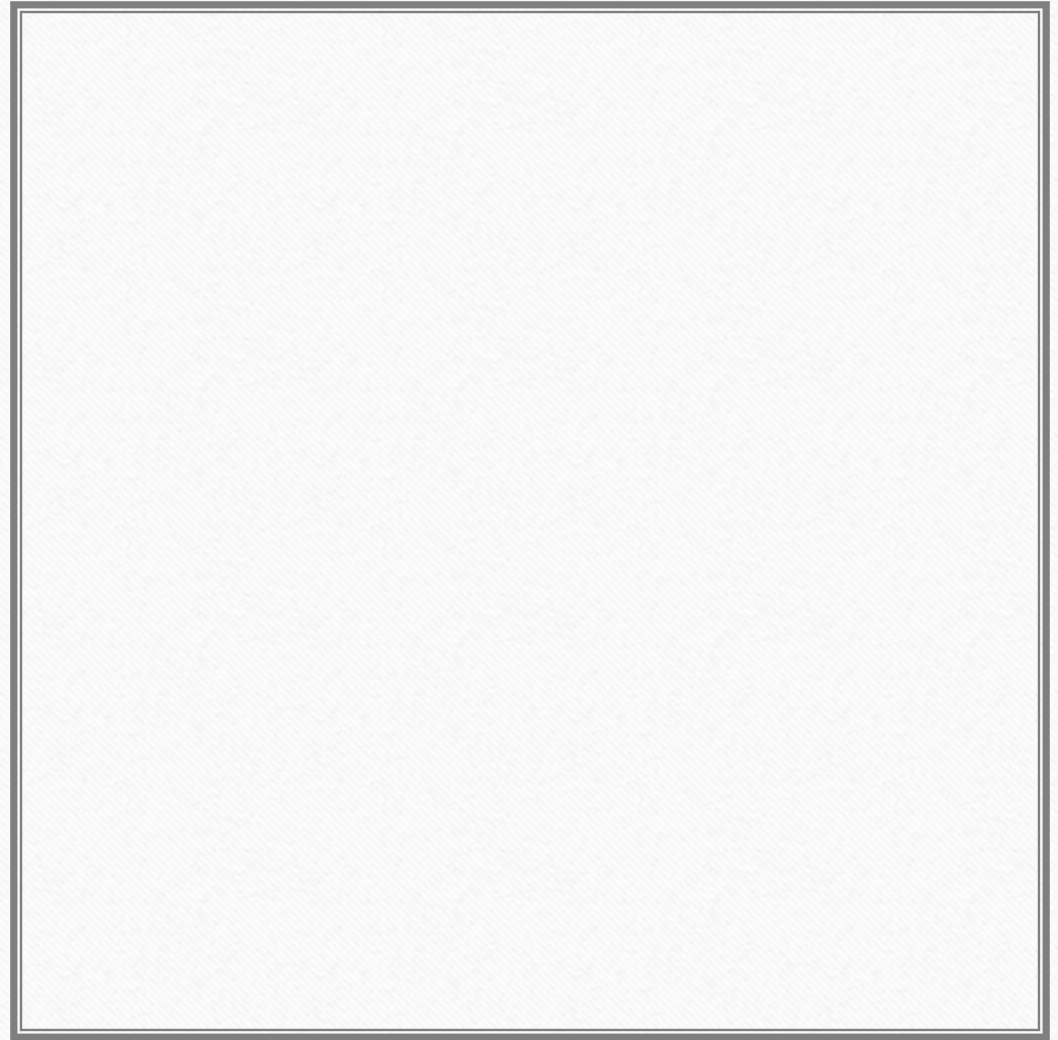
AUGUST 6

Assignment 2

- Due July 27th – tonight
- Worth 20%



Questions
related to the
Assignment?



What do you think about
when you hear AI and
Urban Change?

Artificial Intelligence

- “AI, which involves machines being programmed to think and learn like humans, has the potential to greatly change urban planning and development”(p.508).
- “By using AI technology, city planners and policymakers can access valuable information and data-driven analyses to make informed decisions that support efficient, sustainable, and livable cities” (p.508).

Marwan Al-Raei

Do we think AI is changing the way cities are planned or experienced? Why or why not?

CityNews
Everywhere

News ▾ Watch ▾ Listen ▾ Weather Traffic Gas Prices Contests ▾

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Opposition brewing as data centre capacity is set to explode across Canada



People opposed to AI data centres demonstrate outside council chambers at city hall in Hamilton, Ont., on Wednesday, July 15, 2026. THE CANADIAN PRESS/Nick Iwanyshyn The Canadian Press

By Anja Karadeglija, The Canadian Press
Posted July 18, 2026 6:00 am. Last Updated July 18, 2026 7:23 am.

<https://toronto.citynews.ca/2026/07/18/opposition-brewing-as-data-centre-capacity-is-set-to-explode-across-canada/>

AI-controlled traffic lights coming to Yonge Street as part of Toronto's plan to ease gridlock

By **Beth Macdonell**

Published: April 07, 2026 at 6:39PM EDT



AI and Planning

- <https://www.cp24.com/politics/toronto-city-hall/2026/04/07/ai-controlled-traffic-lights-coming-to-yonge-street-as-part-of-torontos-plan-to-ease-gridlock/?taid=69d5c4d76196360001551319>

TORONTO SUN

Toronto & GTA



City of Toronto seeks use of AI for faster pothole repairs

Mayor Olivia Chow brought issue to executive committee 'to address the particularly tough freeze and thaw cycle this winter'

Spiro Papuckoski

Published Mar 10, 2026 • Last updated Mar 10, 2026 • 2 minute read

6 Comments



Work crews repaired more than 257,000 potholes last year in Toronto. PHOTO BY JACK BOLAND / FILES /Toronto Sun

AI and Planning

- <https://torontosun.com/news/local-news/toronto-ai-faster-pothole-repairs>

Toronto

Toronto rolling out AI chatbot to help residents navigate 311 services

AI chatbot one of several changes being made to make 311 easier: city



Lane Harrison · CBC News · Posted: Jun 17, 2026 4:00 AM EDT | Last Updated: June 17



Listen to this article ⓘ

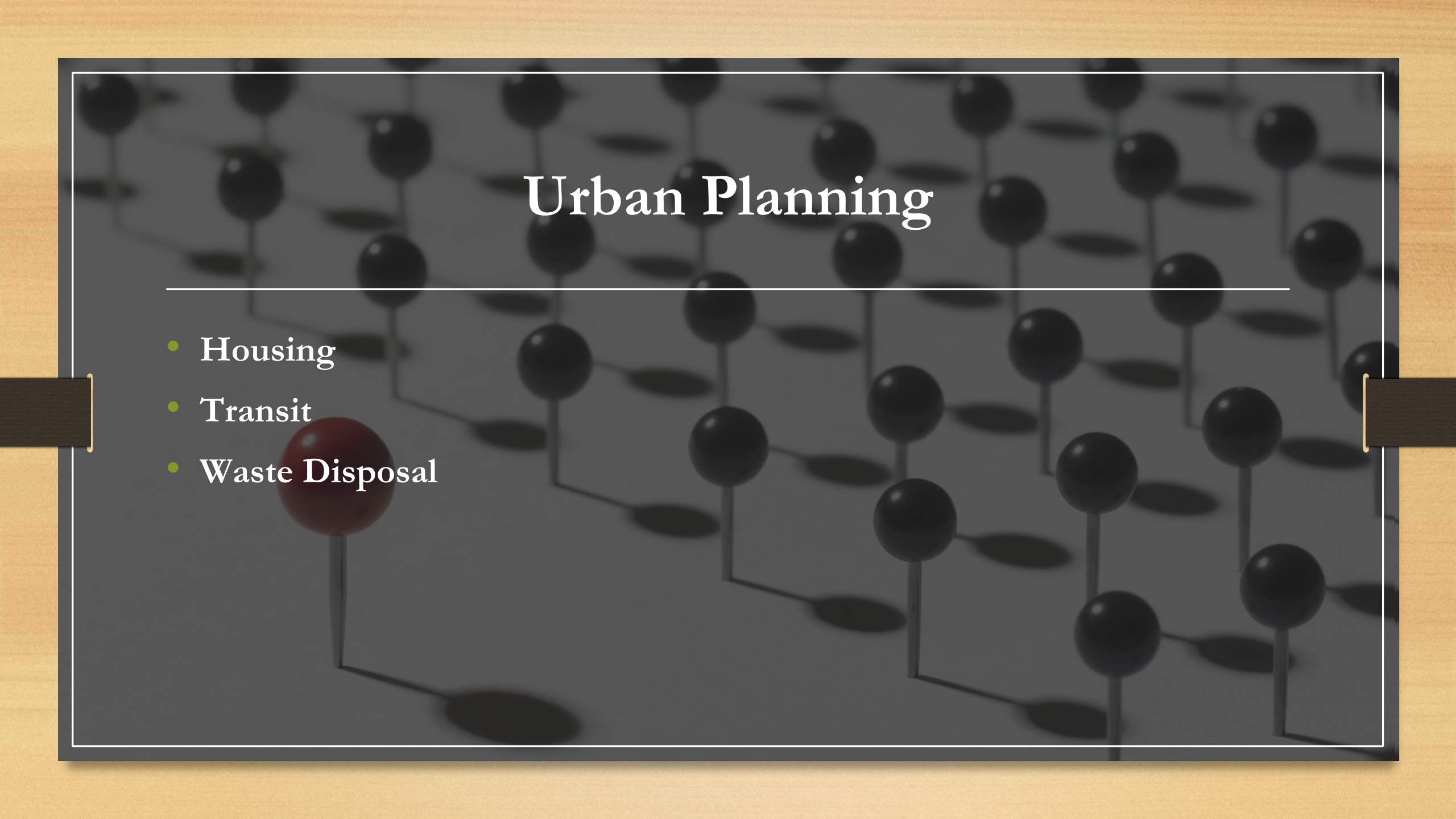
Estimated 3 minutes



AI and Planning

- <https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/toronto-ai-chatbot-311-9.7237699>

Urban Planning

The background of the slide features a complex molecular model. It consists of numerous black spheres connected by thin, dark lines, creating a web-like structure. A single, prominent red sphere is located in the lower-left quadrant of the image. The entire scene is set against a dark, textured background that resembles a close-up of a surface with small, repeating patterns.

-
- Housing
 - Transit
 - Waste Disposal

Urban Planning

- Data Processing
- Sustainable Development
- Disaster Management



Break - 5 Minutes


```
mirror object to mirror_x  
mirror_mod.mirror_object =
```

```
operation == "MIRROR_X":  
    mirror_mod.use_x = True  
    mirror_mod.use_y = False  
    mirror_mod.use_z = False  
operation == "MIRROR_Y":  
    mirror_mod.use_x = False  
    mirror_mod.use_y = True  
    mirror_mod.use_z = False  
operation == "MIRROR_Z":  
    mirror_mod.use_x = False  
    mirror_mod.use_y = False  
    mirror_mod.use_z = True
```

```
selection at the end -add  
mirror_ob.select= 1  
mirror_ob.select=1  
context.scene.objects.active  
("Selected" + str(modifier_name))  
mirror_ob.select = 0  
= bpy.context.selected_objects  
data.objects[one.name].select  
print("please select exactly one")
```

```
-- OPERATOR CLASSES --
```

```
types.Operator):  
    X mirror to the selected  
    object.mirror_mirror_x"  
    mirror X"
```

Can AI Usage Deepen Inequality and Is AI Objective?

AI and Inequality

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cxEjQFUrXTA>
- If AI learns from unequal housing markets, what will happen?
- If AI informs policing, what can we expect?

AI and Urban Change

Mattern (2020) argues “we need to see data’s human, institutional and technological creators, its curators, its preservers, its owners and brokers, its “users,” its hackers and critics” (p.22).

- **Bias – who owns and operates it?**
- **Transparency and accountability**
- **Employment**
- **Policing and surveillance**

Connections to Our Course

- Right to the City – Who is considered? Who will participate?
 - Creative Class and attracting talent/investment
 - Sustainable Development
 - Socio-spatial Exclusion
-
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cxEjQFUrXTA>

AI and Knowledge – The city is not a computer

- Mattern argues that “it’s essential to make space in our cities for those diverse methods of knowledge production” (p.25).
- “We need to think about urban epistemologies that embrace memory and history” (p.25).
- “Urban Intelligence of this kind involves site-based experiences, participant observation, sensory engagement (p.25).

Shannon Mattern, 2020

COURSE EVALUATION

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Discussion

- Please check the tab under the materials for this week on the modules page.
- Upload by the end of class - 1pm.
- Please respond in 120 – 250 words.

Drawing on two examples from today's lecture, do you think AI is more likely to reduce or deepen urban inequalities? Explain your answer and identify one measure that government or planners could take to help ensure AI is used more equitably in cities.

Smart Cities - Sidewalk Labs Links

For those interested:

- <https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/politicians-business-leaders-want-sidewalk-labs-project-scrapped-1.5023860>
- <https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/toronto/sidewalk-labs-cancels-project-1.5559370>

Next Steps

- Tutorial 5 – August 6th
- Final Lecture

